# GAL RAZ

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## PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Cognitive scientist (Ph.D., MIT) working at the intersection of research, open scientific tooling, and applied institution-building. Currently Scientific Director of Dabtong House in Bhutan, Program Director at the Technology Commons Alliance, and a researcher at the Henkaku Center in Japan, with prior project leadership at the Gelephu Mindfulness City.

## WORK EXPERIENCE

2026-present **Founder & Scientific Director, Dabtong House, Bhutan**

- Founded a non-profit that funds and coordinates projects in Bhutan spanning AI, space research, novel construction methods and traditional craft
- Run the AI Studio programme, building a community of technologists in Bhutan

2026-present **Program Director, Technology Commons Alliance, Palo Alto, CA**

- Advancing infrastructure for openly-governed AI

2026-present **Advisor, Gaudiy, Inc., Tokyo, Japan**

2026-present **Advisor, Shiba AI, Tokyo, Japan**

2024-present **Researcher, Henkaku Center, Chiba Institute of Technology, Japan**

- Leading research collaborations between Chiba Institute of Technology and Bhutan's sovereign wealth fund and government technology agencies
- Integrating AI tooling into Chiba Tech's curricula with industry partners

2024-2026 **Project Manager, Gelephu Mindfulness City, Bhutan**

- Founding member of the Gelephu Mindfulness City ("GMC") team, an autonomous Special Administrative Region in southern Bhutan led by His Majesty the King, building an economic hub that measures success with Gross National Happiness
- Set up a corporate registry with lawyers, tax experts and engineers, onboarding the first ~50 companies; migrated thousands of businesses into GMC's independent registry, tax, and customs framework
- Researched and implemented policy on commercial company matters, land ownership and digital assets

2024-2025 **Visiting Scientist, Brain & Cognitive Sciences, MIT** (Part-time)

- Advised on and extended software built during PhD; studied function learning in infants and toddlers (PI: Prof. Laura Schulz)

2019-2024 **PhD Student, Brain & Cognitive Sciences, MIT**

- Devised an automated pipeline for collecting infant behavioral data, a 15x speed-up over traditional methods, collecting data from >700 infants
- Developed a rational choice model of attention (optimal decision theory + Bayesian inference), resulting in three first-author publications
- Core member of the ManyBabies 2 and ManyBabies 5 analysis teams, organizing a consortium of labs to replicate key results in Theory of Mind and attentional preferences
- Supervised 12 undergraduate and Masters students; Head TA for "Infant and Early Childhood Cognition"

## EDUCATION

2024 **PhD** in Brain & Cognitive Sciences (*4.0 GPA*), MIT
2018 **MSc** in Psychological Research (*with distinction*), University of Oxford
2016 **BSc** (Hons.) in Liberal Arts and Sciences (*summa cum laude*), University College Utrecht

## AWARDS

2024 Best Paper in Developmental Psychology, American Psychological Association
2022-2024 ICoN Graduate Fellowship
2021 Walle Nauta Award for Excellence in Undergraduate Teaching
2020 Cheng Graduate Fellowship
2018 Humphrey Prize for Best Research Project Dissertation in MSc cohort
2017 Full scholarship for MSc studies by German Academic Exchange Services
2016 Kupcinet-Getz Scholar at Weizmann Institute of Science

## SELECTED PUBLICATIONS (full list on Google Scholar)

ManyBabies 5 Consortium (in prep). A large-scale investigation of the proposed shift from familiarity to novelty preference in infant looking time.

ManyBabies 2 Consortium (under review). Action anticipation based on an agent's epistemic state in toddlers and adults.

**Raz, G.***, Cao, A.*, Saxe, R., & Frank, M.C. (2025). A stimulus-computable rational model of habituation in infants and adults. *eLife* (*equal contribution)

**Raz, G.**, Piccolo, S., Medrano, J., Liu, S., Lydic, K., et al. (2024). An asynchronous, hands-off workflow for looking time experiments with infants. *Developmental Psychology* (Editor's Choice Award)

**Raz, G.** & Saxe, R. (2020). Learning in Infancy Is Active, Endogenously Motivated, and Depends on the Prefrontal Cortices. *Annual Review of Developmental Psychology*, 2, 247-268.

## COMMUNITY SERVICE AND OUTREACH

2017 - present Volunteer at Dhamma Meditation Centers — serve at 10-day silent retreats (Germany, Israel, UK); lead teams of 8-10 cooking for 100-200 meditators.
2020 - 2024 Graduate Student Council, MIT School of Science — advised the Dean's office; implemented an internship policy and relocation stipend for incoming graduates.
2017 English & Math teacher, Lamdon Jamyang School, Ladakh — 6-month placement teaching children aged 6-13 in northern India.

## MISCELLANEOUS SKILLS AND EXPERIENCES

**Languages**: German, English and Hebrew (fluent), Spanish (level B2), Korean (A1)

**Programming languages (in order of proficiency)**: Python, R, Stan, MATLAB, JavaScript, Unity scripting (C#), WebPPL

**Teaching Certifications:** Graduate Teaching Certificate @ MIT Teaching + Learning Lab, TEFL Certificate (120-hour course for teaching English as a foreign language)

**For fun**: Vipassana meditation, Judo, Yoga, chess, poker, RTS games, electronic music